

installation size, with a footprint of a little over 2 MB. However, this small size is reflected poorly in its clunky and bare interface. The layout is similar to Windows Explorer, but the main window opens with nothing displayed. A more helpful approach could have been adopted for average users, with possibly even a simple wizard included.

The online help in Stellar Phoenix is not very extensive, but it does include a brief chapter on the physical installation of a hard disk, which if printed, could be very useful for a novice to install a new device after a disk crash.

In our speed tests, Stellar Phoenix zoomed through the test folder and completed the scan in an astounding 12 seconds.

Unlike the other tools tested, Stellar Phoenix doesn't support the creation of a rescue boot disk for booting up a system immediately after a crash. Actually, it couldn't detect the floppy drive at all. On certain occasions, it failed to correctly detect the test hard disk, displaying an unknown device identifier instead.

As for the rest of our tests, Stellar Phoenix performed exceptionally well in the partition test by recovering the complete file and folder structure. In the documents test, the results were similar to EasyRecovery with the same ratio of 8 and 7 files recovered, fully and partially respectively. In the end, Stellar Phoenix is a good product, but could do with some improvement to become a truly world-class product.

- + Very low scanning and recovery time, very small installation size

- Low on features

Auto Backup 2.2				
Performance	■	■	■	■
Features	■	■	■	■
Ease of use	■	■	■	■
Overall	■	■	■	■

Conclusion

On the whole, in terms of ease of use and user-friendliness, OnTrack's EasyRecovery was far ahead of the others in the comparison. However, the performance of R-Studio in the tests later, and also the presence of its additional tools, made the difference, and hence it emerged on top. As for Stellar

Windows System Restore

Microsoft, too, has a recovery utility called System Restore, built into Windows. System Restore, however, has very limited functionality compared to recovery suites. System Restore was incorporated into the newer OSes, starting with Windows Me and XP. System Restore can be done by manually setting restore points at regular intervals and restoring from them, or using Automatic restore points usually set by the computer at pre-determined times. It is usually active by default, but if you need to activate it, right-click My Computer, and then click Properties from the menu. In the next dialog box, click on the System Restore tab and uncheck the corresponding checkbox. This tab also allows for more advanced control on the amount of space that can be reserved for System Restore on each drive. This is very important as each restore point takes up quite a bit of space, and as the restore points add up, the effective free space gets reduced, and the hard disk gets fragmented. However, older restore points can be cleared by Disk Cleanup, leaving only the most recent point on the disk.

CATEGORY	DATA RECOVERY SOFTWARE		
Developer	Ontrack	R-Tools Technology Inc.	Stellar Information Systems
Product Name	EasyRecovery Pro	R-Studio FAT	Stellar Phoenix
Ease of Use	24	18.75	15
Installation (Scale of 5)	4	4	4
Configuration (Scale of 5)	4	3	3
Interface (Scale of 5)	4	2.5	3
Updating (Scale of 5)	4	3	0
Features	15	22.5	0
Emergency recovery boot disk creation	✓	✓	✗
Recovery over network	✗	✓	✗
Specific file repair tools	✓	✗	✗
Supports system restoration tools	✗	✓	✗
Performance	11.77	12.82	18.84
Scanning speeds (seconds)	39.39	50.1	12.7
Installation size (MB)	53.6	3.39	2.12
Deleted files completely recovered	8	7	8
Partially recovered	7	7	7
Lost	0	1	0
Complete partition recovery (Scale of 5)	3	2.5	4
Total	50.77	54.07	33.84
Web site	www.ontrack.com	www.r-tt.com	www.stellarinfo.com

Phoenix, although it did really well in the tests, it would have fared much better with a better interface, and possibly a small wizard.

And the winners are...

The loss of data due to an OS crash or a disk failure is often a traumatic experience for novices and can make them wary of computing. It's of even greater concern to business firms that depend heavily on facts and figures stored on hard disks. Hence, it is imperative that corporate houses, as well as home users have a pre-defined back-up and recovery strategy.

Drive Image 7 and GoBack are the two software that are well suited to the task of large-scale data management. GoBack proved itself worthy with the speed and efficiency with which it took snapshots. The fast and one-touch restore capabilities of Drive Image 7 showed that it's capable of managing huge amounts of data with agility.

For small offices and home users, daily backups are not so much of a hassle as compared to restoration of files. This makes WinBackup the most obvious choice—it provides high security, encrypts backups, and even saves them on multiple CDs.

Of all the software tested in our comparison test, a few stood out on the basis of their reliability and user-friendliness. A good combination of performance and features makes Second Copy 2000 a viable alternative for use in small offices that are fitted with a simple LAN. R-Studio proved itself a very reliable software that can recover data in the event of a crash. Its network recovery capabilities made it a tool favoured by network administrators. On the other hand, EasyRecovery, with its eye-catching interface and simple wizards is, by far, the utility best suited for users who are not familiar with the process of recovery.

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